

S. INIYAN

An Auto Driver's *Lessons in Customer Care*

His pride in his job has brought Annadurai to the notice of business titans

By **T.V.S. SOMU**

Annadurai, a 38-year-old auto driver in Chennai, recently shot to national fame for taking public transport to a whole new level. Big corporate houses have invited him to speak to their employees about business management, and many top executives have showered him with praise. Anand Mahindra tweeted: 'If MBA students spent a day with [Annadurai], it would be a compressed course in customer experience management. This man's not only an auto driver... he's a professor of management.' Recently, Annadurai was even called upon by the DGP (director general of police) of Tamil Nadu, Dr C. Sylendra Babu, who presented him with a certificate of recognition.

A resident of Chennai's Injambakkam, Annadurai decided that he wanted to make travelling an especially pleasant experience for his customers. In his auto, passengers have access to several daily newspapers and weekly magazines and the vehicle is also equipped with a small smart TV, free WiFi and a fridge in which ice-cold water and juices are available. There also has a jar with fruits, chocolate and chips for travellers to snack on. Annadurai has also equipped his auto with digital tools to give passengers a sense of the traffic ahead on their journey.

What's more, he provides all these services for free. "I want to make the trip enjoyable and useful for passengers," says Annadurai. He also makes an extra effort for those with disabilities—for example, he has installed a sign language tool for those who cannot hear. He also keeps five or six umbrellas in the auto to give to passengers in case of a sudden shower, which can be returned on their next ride with him. He says he has no worries about passengers cheating him by not returning the item. He has also set up a system for feedback, and says he

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"I sincerely love this career. I thought it would be nice to put in some utilities for customers"

— ANNADURAI